

“It’s A Misconception That Startups Universally Pay Less.”

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For key roles and skill sets, compensation at startups often matches or even exceeds corporate standards, says Shashwath T.R. of Mindgrove Technologies in conversation with Akanksha S. Gaur.

How is that possible? What makes startups more appealing to professionals than corporates? And what kind of skills do they value most? The answers lie in this insightful discussion.

What are the biggest skill gaps electronics startups face, and do they go beyond technical knowledge?

Yes, the gaps extend well beyond technical fundamentals. **Startups often struggle to find professionals with mid-level expertise who possess genuine design intuition and the ability to bridge theory with practical implementation.** Beyond circuit laws or basic engineering skills, experience in tasks such as chip tapeout, system prototyping,

and cross-domain product thinking is difficult to source. We also seek individuals who can blend technical expertise with creativity to bridge chip design to real-world applications. These deficits in mid- and higher-level expertise are often more challenging than addressing entry-level knowledge gaps, which structured training can usually help fill.

How critical are these skill gaps when scaling an electronics startup?

These gaps are highly critical because scaling requires much more than individual excellence; it needs cohesive teams that execute reliably under pressure. A shortage of seasoned designers or product thinkers can stall innovation pipelines, slow prototyping, and lead to costly production errors. Additionally, soft skills such as collaboration, adaptability, and cross-functional communication are just as important as technical expertise. In small startup teams, every hire plays a significant role, but retention is a challenge since larger corporations often lure away trained professionals. **Therefore, scaling successfully depends not only on closing technical gaps but also on building a strong organisational culture that attracts and retains talent.**

What makes an engineering graduate or master's student stand out to a startup like Mindgrove?

Startups value proof of ability over formal credentials. Graduates who have built, shipped, or meaningfully contributed to real projects, such as participating in ‘Tiny Tapeout’ or documenting the full